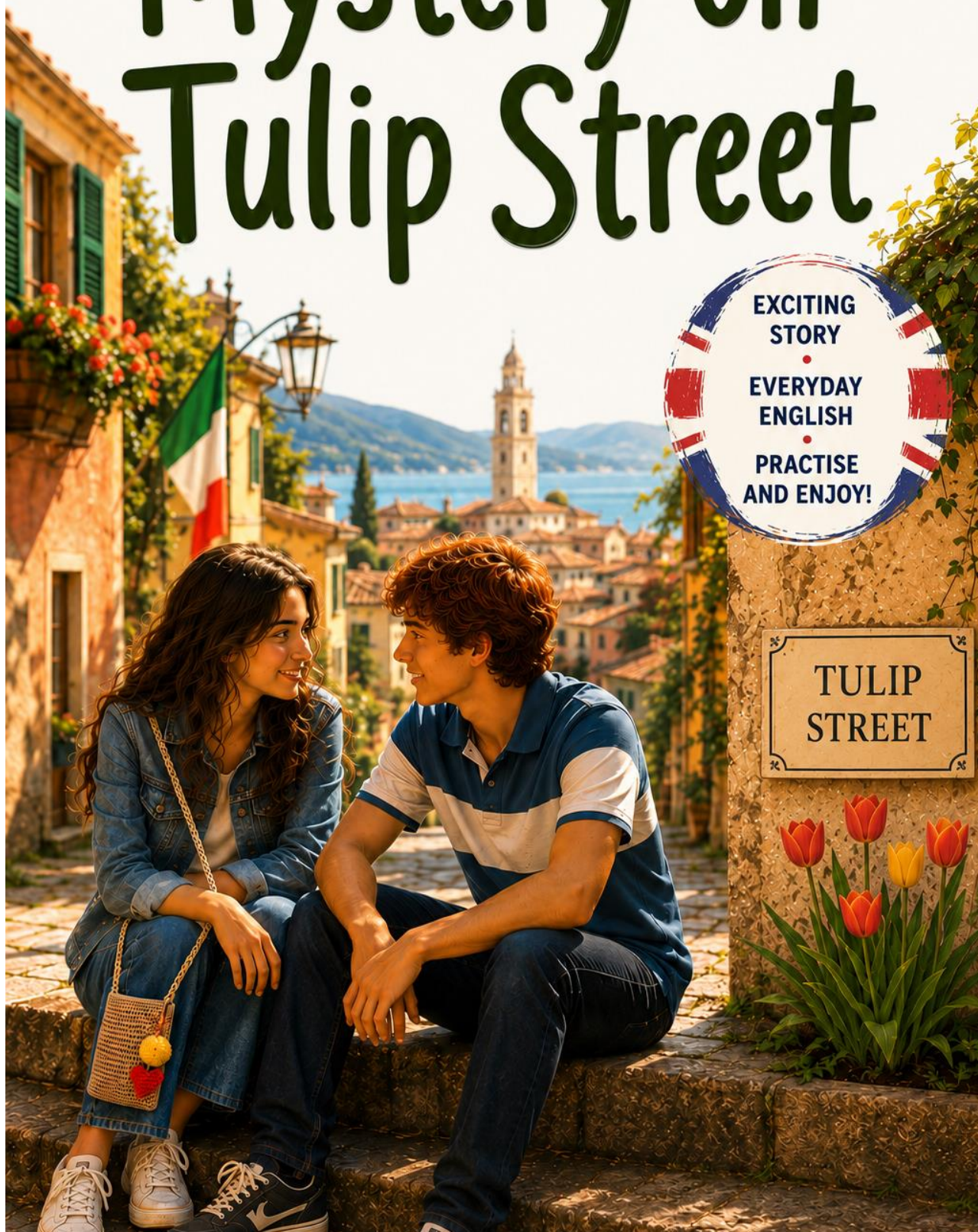


A1-A2 Level
Graded Readings for Learners

Mystery on Tulip Street

EXCITING
STORY
•
EVERYDAY
ENGLISH
•
PRACTISE
AND ENJOY!

TULIP
STREET



Friday, evening

It is evening. A spring evening.

— Finally home — says Giacomo and puts his bicycle next to the entrance of the building on Tulip Street.

This is where he lives.

Every Tuesday and Friday, Giacomo goes to football practice. His team trains on a field near his house, and he goes there and comes back by bike.

— Hi, Giacomo — a girl who arrives at that moment greets him.

— Hi, Simona.

Simona is a tall and slender girl, with chestnut hair and blue eyes.

“How beautiful she is...” thinks Giacomo.

Every time he meets her, he doesn’t know what to say or what to do. He looks at her and smiles like an idiot. Giacomo is sixteen years old, but he is very shy and still doesn’t know how to behave with girls. Luckily, she talks a lot.

— I went to buy coffee at the supermarket right in front — she is saying.

— Mom forgot it. I just made it in time. I arrived at ten to eight, and the supermarket closes at eight.

Giacomo sees a sign in front of the elevator: “Out of order.”

— It’s broken again. We have to go up on foot — she says.

The two go up the stairs.

— Listen, how loud this music is! — says Simona.

— Yes, it’s at disco volume. It’s probably coming from Mr. Cassi’s apartment. He always listens to music very loudly.

— Maybe when he was young, he was a clubber?

— Do you think so? — Giacomo asks doubtfully.

He thinks about Mr. Cassi: a small, thin man, with a face that always looks grey and serious. Then he continues:

— He seems like someone who has never been young. And besides, were there even nightclubs in his time? — he says jokingly.

— Of course! He looks old, but he isn’t. My mom said he is not even fifty.



Now the two teenagers are on the second floor, right in front of Mr. Cassi's apartment. From his apartment, the music of a song by Gloria Gaynor can be heard.

Giacomo and Simona live on the third floor: Simona with her mother and her little brother Federico, Giacomo with his parents.

Giacomo says goodbye to Simona and goes into his home.

— Dinner is ready — says Giacomo's mother.

The teenager sits down at the table with his family.

— This terrible music! — his mother complains. — Today, it just won't stop...

— Does it bother you? — Giacomo asks.

— Yes, it's too loud. All our neighbors say so too.

— And Mr. Cassi knows it — the father comments. — The building manager has even written him a letter. He asked him to stop all this noise. Otherwise, he will get into trouble.

— And what about him? — Giacomo asks.

— He hasn't even replied.

Giacomo is eating the spaghetti that his mother has put on the table when his father asks him:

— Giacomo! Where did you put the bicycle?

— Mmm... down... near the entrance.

— You know that the neighbors complain if they see bicycles or motorbikes near the entrance!

— I know.

— Then finish eating and go, please!

It is eight forty. Giacomo leaves the apartment. He goes down the stairs and passes in front of Mr. Cassi's apartment.

Now there is only silence.

"Luckily he turned off the stereo," Giacomo thinks.

He goes out of the building, takes the bicycle and puts it in the garage. He comes back in and goes up the stairs. In the silence of the building, he hears a door opening and closing. On the second floor, he passes again in front of Mr. Cassi's apartment and sees the door open.

"How strange," Giacomo says to himself.

But Mr. Cassi is strange too, so he doesn't think about it anymore.

Mr. Cassi's door is open, and there's no more music. What do you think happened?

Saturday, morning

Today is Saturday, and Giacomo does not go to school because there is a teachers' strike. So he will sleep at least until ten.

But... today something is different. Today his mother enters his room at ten to eight.

— Giacomo, Giacomo — she calls.

Giacomo is dreaming: he is a football player in a famous team and he is in a big stadium. This is an important match. There are many people — so many people. And he... he is scoring a goal! All around him, the crowd is shouting his name: “Giacomo! Giacomo!”

He opens his eyes. No, it is not the crowd shouting his name, it is his mother.

— Giacomo, Giacomo! — she repeats. — Wake up!

— Why? What’s happening? — Giacomo asks, now awake.

— Something bad has happened.

His mother looks at him and does not speak. She seems very worried.

— What?

— Mr. Cassi is dead. They say... they killed him.

— When?

— Maybe yesterday evening, or during the night, they still don’t know.

“Poor Mr. Cassi!” thinks Giacomo.

— Do they already have any suspects? — asks Giacomo.

But his mother does not have time to answer because someone rings the doorbell.

— It must be the police. They’re going to all the apartments asking questions.

Indeed, outside the door there are two police officers: one young, the other older.

— Do you have any information for us? Any suspicions? — asks the younger one.

— Yes — answers Giacomo, and he tells them about the previous evening.

The loud music, the bicycle, the sound of a door closing, Mr. Cassi’s door left open.

— Mmmh, the sound of a door closing. It could have been the door of another apartment — says the younger policeman.

— So the murderer could be someone from the building? — asks the other officer.

— One of our neighbors! — exclaims the mother. — Oh, God!

— Ma’am, don’t panic! These are only assumptions. The investigation has just begun.

They leave. Giacomo gets dressed and immediately goes outside.

— You must be home by noon. Dad is coming back from work at that time today — his mother tells him.

Giacomo is in the garden with his football. There are two police cars there. There are also many people. The usual curious people who want to see what happened.

Giacomo stands in the garden holding the ball; he does not want to play, he only wants to hear what the police officers are saying.

They go in and out, talk among themselves, and Giacomo manages to overhear an interesting conversation:

— The neighbors all seem like quiet people to me — says the older policeman. — We should follow the trail of Mr. Cassi's friendships. He had some questionable friends!

— I agree with you — confirms the other one.

The police want to investigate Mr. Cassi's friendships. Do you think Giacomo agrees with them?

Saturday, noon

Giacomo comes home. He is angry.

— So they don't believe me? Maybe they think: "The boy invented the story about the door just to feel important."

While he is going upstairs, he hears his mother's voice: she is talking with their neighbor, Miss Valle.

Miss Valle always knows everything about everyone. She lives alone in her apartment on the second floor and spends the whole day watching the neighbors.

Giacomo stops to listen to what she is saying to his mother:

— I was the one who found Mr. Cassi. I always wake up early in the morning because I sleep very little. You know, at my age... I went out to take the dog outside. And... oh, but who are those people? — Miss Valle looks curiously toward the staircase.

Few people are coming upstairs.

— They're not police officers, are they? — says Miss Valle with a big smile. — One of them has a camera. Those are journalists!

She is right. They really are journalists. They ask if they can interview her.

Miss Valle answers:

— Yeeees! — and adds — It has always been my dream to be on television!



Miss Valle talks a lot. She says that she found the body early in the morning. She passed by the open door, called out loudly to Mr. Cassi, but he did not answer. So she went inside.

— You were very brave — the journalist tells her. She smiles shyly.

— Oh no, oh no... — and then she says her classic phrase, the one she always repeats: — At my age, and you know...

But Giacomo is no longer listening. Miss Valle keeps talking and talking, but she knows nothing.

At that moment Simona arrives. She has just left her apartment.

— Did you hear? — Giacomo immediately asks her.

— Yes, poor Mr. Cassi!

— Exactly.

— Does the police have any suspects?

— Yes, they suspect Mr. Cassi's friends. But I'm not convinced.

— What do you mean?

— Come with me, I'll tell you something!

Simona follows Giacomo into his apartment and into his room.

The mother is surprised: never before had Giacomo brought a girl home!

“My son is so shy,” she had always thought.

Giacomo tells Simona what he heard the previous evening.

— So, according to you, one of our neighbors killed Mr. Cassi — says the girl.

— Yes, that's what I think.

— Fine, you told the police. Now it's their job.

— But the police are following another lead!

— So, what do you want to do?

— I want to investigate.

— Investigate? You? Alone?

— With you, if you want.

— Oh, yes. I've always dreamed of being a detective.



Giacomo's plan is simple: before dinner, he and Simona will go to all the neighbors' apartments.

They will ask for sugar. They will say they are making a cake, but they realized at the last moment that they had run out of sugar. With this excuse, they will be able to enter the neighbors' apartments and talk to each of them.

— And do you think they'll say anything useful?

— Let's hope so!

— Fine, I'm with you. When shall we meet?

— At six thirty.

— Okay.

Giacomo walks her to the door. He looks at her.

— Is there still something you want to tell me? — she asks.

“Yes, you are beautiful, you are the most beautiful girl in the world. Will you go out with me?”

Giacomo thinks, but instead he answers:

— No, nothing.

Giacomo and Simona are playing detectives. Are you fascinated by this profession too? What other professions do you like?

Saturday, late afternoon

It is six thirty. Simona is at Giacomo's house.

— We'll go to every apartment. Everyone is a suspect. Except us and our families, of course, and Miss Valle.

— Why not Miss Valle?

— Because she talks too much, and also because... do you know how Mr. Cassi died?

— No.

— Someone hit him with a blunt object. You need strength to do something like that.

— So it can't have been a woman.

— Yes, it could have been a woman, but not Miss Valle. She weighs barely fifty kilos.

— You're right — says Simona.

— So that leaves these people... — Giacomo shows Simona a little sheet with the building plan on it.

— Let's start on the first floor — says Giacomo — Dr. Martino lives here.

The two teenagers ring the doctor's doorbell. A tall man with gray hair opens the door.

— Good evening. What can I do for you? — he asks kindly.

— We're making a dessert — says Giacomo — but at the last moment we realized we don't have any sugar. Could you lend us some?

— Certainly, come in. You live on the third floor, right?

— Yes, above Mr. Cassi's apartment — answers Giacomo, who wants to steer the conversation exactly in that direction.

— Oh, yes... Mr. Cassi. What a terrible thing!

— Did you know him? — Giacomo asks again.

— No, but I know he always made a lot of noise.

— Yesterday too — comments Simona.

— Yesterday I wasn't home — says the doctor. — As I already told the police, I was at the hospital for the night shift...

— Franco, Franco — calls a weak voice coming from a room at the end of the corridor.

— Excuse me. That's my wife. Here! Take the sugar. I have to go to her.

The two leave. Simona rings the doorbell of the Bianchi apartment. Mrs. Bianchi arrives almost immediately.

— Ah! — she exclaims with a big smile. — Our delightful neighbors.

She invites them inside. She is wearing a short dress that leaves her beautiful legs uncovered.

— What do I owe this visit to? — she asks.

— Umm — answers Giacomo awkwardly — we... sugar... ma'am, we need a little sugar. For a cake we're making.

— Ah, I see. I'll bring it to you right away, kids.

She comes back from the kitchen holding a package in her hand. Simona takes it and says:

— You have a quiet apartment.

— Yes, my husband and I wanted it facing the courtyard and not the street — she replies — I can't stand noise.

— Me neither — Giacomo says quickly. — When Mr. Cassi made all that noise...

— Oh yes, all that terrible noise! — she comments, accompanying them to the door.

Now Simona and Giacomo are on the fourth floor, standing at the door of the Moreno family's apartment.

When Simona rings the doorbell, it is the lady of the house who opens the door: she is a slightly heavy woman of about forty years old.

— What do you want? — she asks rather impolitely.

— Sorry to bother you, ma'am — Simona replies, repeating the usual excuse about the cake.

— Yes, yes... — the woman interrupts her. — Come in!

The two teenagers enter the apartment. It is very messy. Two small children are running between the chairs in the living room. Mrs. Moreno goes into the kitchen.

— What's going on here? — asks a man's voice. It is Mr. Moreno.



He walks with long strides. He is not tall, but he seems big and strong because he has broad shoulders and large muscles.

When he sees the two teenagers, he looks surprised.

— Oh! — he exclaims. — A beautiful young lady in my house... what a pleasure! — Then he invites them to sit down.

Meanwhile, Mrs. Moreno comes back carrying the sugar in a beer glass.

— So, how are things going, kids? — the man asks, sitting down as well.

— Not very well after what happened — answers Giacomo, immediately steering the conversation toward the murder.

— Ah yes, of course... Mr. Cassi. Well, yes, a death is always a terrible thing.

— Exactly, and to think that I'm kind of a witness — says the boy, looking Mr. Moreno straight in the eyes.

— You... a witness? — asks the man. — What do you mean?

— I mean that I saw something, or rather, I heard something.

— Heard something?

— Yes, that evening I heard a...

At that moment one of the children runs to his father. He is crying and shouting:

— Daddy, Daddy... I fell down, look at my finger, I broke my finger... — and he keeps crying.

The two teenagers stand up.

— Sorry, we don't want to bother you any longer — says Simona.

— Yes, we're leaving — adds Giacomo, taking the glass with the sugar.

— We'll talk about this again! — says Mr. Moreno seriously, looking at Giacomo.

As soon as they are outside, the two teenagers speak in low voices.

— Mr. Moreno was very curious — says Simona, but she immediately corrects herself. — Curious is not the right word. To me, he seemed... worried. Very worried. He frightened me when he said: "We'll talk about this again!"

Mr. and Mrs. Villa's apartment is on the same floor as the Morenos' apartment.

Giacomo has his finger on the doorbell when Simona exclaims:

— No, Mrs. Villa isn't here! She's at the seaside with her son. My mother told me yesterday. I had forgotten.

— Ah, even better, one suspect less — says Giacomo.

Who do you think is the most suspicious person? Why?

Saturday, evening

The teenagers are once again in Giacomo's apartment.

— So, what do you think? — asks Simona.

— The most suspicious person is definitely Mr. Moreno.

— And what about Mrs. Bianchi? She has crazy eyes!

— To me they seem more like... cat eyes. So big and green.

— No, no, no, definitely crazy eyes. The problem is that you men don't notice because she's a beautiful woman.

Giacomo would like to say: "You are very beautiful too," but, as always, he does not have the courage and stays silent. Instead, he continues talking about the murder:

— I'm excluding Dr. Martino from the list. He was at the hospital last night. He told the police that too. Besides, he seems like a very calm person to me. So that leaves the Morenos and Mrs. Bianchi.

— I agree.

— Anyway, these are only assumptions. We still haven't finished our work.

— And what can we do?

— I'm going down into the garden and staying there as long as necessary. I'll watch the people going in and out. The garden is dark. Nobody will see me.

If necessary, I'll hide behind a tree.

— What do you think you're going to see?

— Someone getting rid of the murder weapon. The police haven't found it. It must still be somewhere in the building.

— I see. How long are you planning to stay there?

— All night, if necessary.

— But it will be... boring!

— I know, but it has to be done. What do you think? A detective's job certainly isn't fun. On the contrary, it's exactly like this: hours and hours sitting and waiting, spying...

— I, if you want, can...

— No, not you! It's boring, but it's also dangerous.

— Fine, as you wish. But please, be careful!

Simona takes Giacomo's hand and gently presses it between hers. And inside him he feels a strange sensation, strong and sweet at the same time.

He would like to kiss her, but a little voice tells him: "Not yet, Giacomo, it's not the right moment yet."

And Giacomo does nothing.

— I'll come to the garden as soon as I can — says Simona, and she leaves.

Giacomo has been in the garden for two hours. He is sitting in the dark, his eyes fixed on the entrance door. It is almost nine thirty when: there is Simona!

In the darkness she cannot see him. He calls her from behind the big tree in the garden:

— I'm here, Simona.

— So, any news? — she asks.

— Yes, something... surprising.

— Half an hour ago, do you know who came into the garden? Two people we know: Mrs. Bianchi and Mr. Moreno. They were here together, hugging each other.

— I can't believe it... So they're lovers.

— I think so. They stayed in the garden for at least fifteen minutes. They talked quietly, and I only heard a few words here and there.

— Now I have to go. My parents don't even know that I went out. What did you tell yours?

— I said I was going to study at a friend's house and sleep there.

— Ah, bye, and... be careful!

He remains under the tree in the silence of the garden and looks at his watch: it is ten o'clock.

"This is going to be a long night," he says to himself.

Giacomo is in the garden. Try to make some guesses about what is going to happen next.

Saturday, night

It is eleven o'clock.

"An hour has passed since Simona left, and nobody has entered or left the building," thinks Giacomo.

It is midnight. Miss Valle has just come back with her dog, Bebi.

It is half past midnight, and Giacomo is beginning to feel tired.

It is one o'clock. Giacomo is more and more tired. His eyes are closing.

Someone is coming out of the building entrance. Giacomo stands up. It is Mr. Moreno. He is carrying a sports bag.

The man walks toward the back of the garden where the garage is located. He walks slowly and looks around.

Giacomo follows him. In the darkness he feels safe: the man cannot see him.

Mr. Moreno opens the garage door. He looks into the bag, then puts a hand to his forehead.

"He forgot something," thinks Giacomo.

Indeed, Mr. Moreno leaves the garage door open and quickly goes back into the building.

Giacomo is standing in a corner of the garden.

Mr. Moreno is entering the building. Giacomo goes into the garage. Mr. Moreno's bag is on the ground. Giacomo opens it. There is only one thing inside: a statue. It is large and heavy.

"This could be the murder weapon," he thinks. He takes the bag and runs toward the building. He is in front of the entrance when suddenly a man appears in front of him. It is Mr. Moreno.

He does not say a word. Without wasting a second, he punches Giacomo, and the boy falls unconscious to the ground.

Giacomo opens his eyes again. He cannot see anything. Everything is dark. He tries to get up, but he cannot.

His hands and feet are tied. And he cannot even shout because his mouth is covered with something, maybe tape.

Little by little, in the darkness, he begins to distinguish a few things: a car, some shelves, a... Now he understands where he is!

“He locked me in the garage!” he thinks.



Then he hears a voice. It is Mr. Moreno's voice:

— Now we're going on a nice trip, little boy. Nice for me, maybe not so nice for you.

Mr. Moreno laughs, and it is an ugly laugh, a cruel laugh.

He grabs Giacomo by the shoulders and lifts him up like a puppet.

— That will teach you to spy on people, little boy — he says, putting him into the trunk of the car.

Giacomo is terrified, terribly frightened, but he can do nothing there inside the trunk. He can only wait.

The car starts, moves, then stops.

A few seconds pass, and then Giacomo hears noises, voices, and immediately afterward, the sirens of police cars.

Finally, someone opens the trunk.

A police officer helps the boy get out, and Giacomo finds himself standing in front of...

Why do you think the police arrived?

Sunday, morning

Simona: it was she who called the police.

Now she is telling the whole story to Giacomo and to a police officer:

— It was half past midnight and I couldn't sleep. I was thinking about Giacomo. Alone, maybe in danger. I got up and went to the window. From my window you can see the garden, but not the building entrance. I saw Giacomo running across the garden with a bag in his hand. Right afterward I saw Mr. Moreno. He was walking toward the garage with a body over his shoulders. I understood immediately that it was Giacomo! I called you right away and then I went downstairs. I saw Mr. Moreno in the car. He saw me too and shouted. He got out of the car, and I ran away. Then fortunately you arrived.

— And I'm safe! — exclaims Giacomo.

— You were very reckless — says the police officer. — You took a huge risk.

— Yes, but now we have the culprit.

— It's too early to say that, boy. Now we'll take the statue to the laboratory. The day after tomorrow, the analysis results will tell us whether Mr. Moreno is really guilty.

— You two were crazy!!!

This is Giacomo's father's voice.

The teenagers turn around and see that their parents are there and have heard everything.

They seem very angry.

Simona goes inside, and Giacomo does not even have time to thank her.

The next day is Sunday. It is nine in the morning and everyone is still asleep.

But no... not everyone. Giacomo is awake!

Even though he went to bed late, after getting a long lecture from his parents, he was already up at eight o'clock.

FROM: Simona

Awake?

FROM: Giacomo

Yes.

FROM: Simona

Shall we meet now?

FROM: Giacomo

Yes, in the garden.

In the garden, Giacomo and Simona sit under a tree.



— I'm alive thanks to you — Giacomo says to Simona. She smiles. Gently.

The little voice speaks to Giacomo and tells him: "Now, now. It's time."

And Giacomo, finally, kisses Simona.

Giacomo and Simona walk upstairs. When they pass in front of Mrs. Bianchi's apartment, the door suddenly opens.

— Oh, kids... — she says — why don't you come in? I want to talk to you for a second.

The two go into the apartment.

— Tell me, what happened last night? I heard a lot of noise...

Giacomo looks at Simona for a moment before answering. Then he says:

— The police came. They arrested Mr. Moreno.

— Mr. Moreno? And why?

— For Mr. Cassi's murder. They found him with the murder weapon.

— I see. — Mrs. Bianchi is very serious. She is not smiling as she always does.

— And what do you two have to do with all this?

— It's a long story — says Simona. — Now we really have to go.

— If our parents wake up and don't find us, they'll worry — adds Giacomo.

— Ah ah... They don't know you are together... — she says.

They are standing by the door, and here Mrs. Bianchi asks the final question:

— And what did they do with the statue?

“The statue??? But I never mentioned any statue. I said: murder weapon,” thinks Giacomo.

— What is it? — asks Mrs. Bianchi, noticing the surprised expression on Giacomo's face.

— Nothing, nothing — replies the boy. — Now we really must go, ma'am.

But the woman stands in front of the door.

— You two are not going anywhere right now — she says.

“She understood!” thinks Giacomo, moving closer to Mrs. Bianchi. Giacomo is still a boy, but he is tall, taller than the woman.

— Let us pass — he says.

The woman puts her hand into her pocket and pulls out a... gun. She points it at the two teenagers.

— Good. Now, like good children, do what I tell you. Go into the living room!

“She has a terrible face...” thinks Simona. “She's really frightening.”

— Now sit down!

The two teenagers sit down.

— What do you want to do? If you shoot, the whole building will hear...

— No, my dear. My gun has a silencer. Giacomo, you really are a handsome boy. I'm sorry that I have to shoot you.

Giacomo tries to gain time. And the best way to gain time is... to talk.

— But why? Why do you want to shoot us?

— Ah, you know very well. Mr. Moreno killed nobody. It was me. I killed Cassi. He knew about my relationship with Moreno and wanted to tell everything to my husband.

— But... Mr. Moreno?

— Mr. Moreno is a coward. One of those people who says: “I'll do this, I'll do that...” but he didn't have the courage. I did. The day before yesterday, I was at home alone. I went to Cassi's apartment. He let me in and said to me: “If you're nice to me, maybe I can give you a discount.” I completely lost control with anger. I grabbed a statue from a shelf and hit him, hit him, hit him...

Now even Giacomo notices that Mrs. Bianchi's eyes are strange — not cat eyes, but crazy eyes, just as Simona had said.

But now it is... too late.

The woman has raised the gun toward Simona.

— I don't like you, and I never liked you.

Ding dong ding dong

Someone rings the doorbell. Mrs. Bianchi turns her head toward the door. Giacomo does not waste a second. He jumps forward and throws her to the ground. They struggle, and he manages to take the gun away from her.

Ding dong ding dong — the bell rings again. A voice comes from outside:

— Mrs. Bianchi, it's Miss Valle. I have to tell you something.

Giacomo is now standing up, holding the gun pointed at Mrs. Bianchi.

Simona opens the door.

Miss Valle is standing there together with her dog.

— He did his business here, poor little dog... I'm so sor... — she is saying, but then she suddenly stops. — Simona, what are you doing here? — she asks.

Simona hugs her.

— Oh, Miss Valle! — she says. — I'm so happy to see you!

Ten minutes later, the police are once again in the building on Tulip Street.

Epilogue

One month later

Life in the building on Tulip Street goes on. Apparently just as before.

But something has changed. For Giacomo and Simona. Now they are together. They are happy and in love.

Life has also changed for Mrs. Moreno. Her husband is in prison, and she has left Tulip Street.

Mrs. Bianchi is also in prison, and she will stay there for many years.

They found her fingerprints on the murder weapon, there are Giacomo and Simona's testimonies, and finally even Mr. Moreno admitted that she was the killer.

Life has not changed, however, for one person: Miss Valle. She still walks around with her dog.

There are no more police officers or journalists, nobody asking questions. And she is bored and... waiting.

Who knows? Sooner or later, maybe something else will happen on Tulip Street...